



Beijing 2008

BOXING

The boys from BHIWANI

INDIA TODAY begins its countdown to the 2008 Beijing Olympics with the remarkable story of how a nondescript town became India's boxing capital

■ By Ramesh Vinayak in Bhiwani

The Beijing Olympics are still three weeks away, but an air of excitement already hangs thick in Bhiwani, a backwater district of Haryana. If animated conversation in its languid *chaupals* and dusty playfields is any indication, this sandy corner of Jatland is savouring the prospect of having provided four out of five boxers to the Indian boxing contingent headed to Beijing. It's a feat no other Indian town can boast of.

Having made the cut for Beijing, the foursome—Akhil Kumar, Vijender Singh, Jitender and Dinesh—are now the poster boys for Bhiwani, a new powerhouse of Indian boxing. The town's previous record came at the 2004 Athens Olympics, when three of four Indian boxers were Bhiwani natives.

The Bhiwani quartet to Beijing is led by Akhil, 27, a 54-kg boxer, declared the 'Best boxer in Asia' in the Olympic qualifier and tipped as India's best medal bet for the 2008 Games. Vijender Singh, 22, a middleweight (75 kg) boxer enters Beijing on a high, having beaten the Athens gold medallist Bakhtiyar Artigev in a pre-Olympic event. Light heavyweight Dinesh Kumar, 20, is an 81-kg southpaw who knocked out both his opponents to win his ticket to Beijing. The junior-most in the team, flyweight (51kg) Jitender Kumar, 20, is both swift of foot and quickwitted.

The only non-Bhiwani boxer in the team is featherweight Akhilesh Kumar

Lakra from the Services, a ratio that reflects a shift in the balance of power in Indian boxing, which has moved away from the dominance of Services fighters.

Chief National Boxing Coach G.S. Sandhu calls Bhiwani the "Cuba of India", a title the town has earned in the last decade by doggedly nurturing a deep-seated passion for boxing among its rural youth. The sport is now the new leitmotif for a place previously known for its textile industry and two home-grown chief ministers.

No other sport, not even cricket,

THE HARYANA FOURSOME

DINESH KUMAR, 20
The 81kg southpaw
knocked out two rivals
in the qualifiers

AKHIL KUMAR, 27
He was declared the
'Best boxer in Asia' in
the Olympic qualifier

VIJENDER SINGH, 22
Beat Athens gold medal-
list Bakhtiyar Artigev
in a pre-Olympic event

JITENDER KUMAR, 20
The youngest in the
team, he is both swift of
foot and quickwitted

